Kumar was a minister in the Vajpayee-led NDA government. Unlike Ram Vilas Paswan who resigned in protest, Nitish stayed on in the government. Nor did he call for Modi's removal. If he did protest, it was only in private. The public face of the NDA was Vajpayee, and Nitish appeared content with the prime minister's inclusive image. He even visited Gujarat as railway minister and shared a stage with Modi.

Nitish's formal break with Modi really began only in November 2005 when he formed a majority government for the first time. That's when he realized that his long-term political future hinged on reaching out to at least a section of the state's Muslims. He could not be a durable chief minister of a state with a Muslim population of 16 to 18 per cent by ignoring their concerns. One of those concerns was the nature of the Janata Dal (United)'s alliance government with the BJP. So, Nitish drew a Lakshman-rekha for his partners—his government would be guided by secular principles as defined by his socialist past. Protecting Muslim interests was an unwavering commitment. To that end, Bihar would be off limits for Modi. The BJP, as the junior partner, accepted the conditions.

Nitish had built a strong personal equation, in particular with Jaitley. Whenever he visited Delhi, he'd go to Jaitley's house for dinner. He also had a special connect with his deputy, Sushil Modi of the BJP, who had gone to university with him. With Bihar's Modi by his side, he believed he didn't need to worry about having to deal with a Modi in distant Gujarat.

Two events changed it all. The first occurred during the 2009 general election campaign. The NDA was holding a joint rally in Ludhiana as a grand show of strength under the leadership of their prime ministerial nominee, Advani. Nitish was reluctant to go, fearing Modi would also be present. Jaitley assured him that this was a personal invite from Advani and his presence was important. Nitish had grown to respect Advani; he agreed to make the trip.

No sooner had Nitish stepped onto the stage, Modi rushed to greet him, took his hand and held it aloft to the cheering crowd. It may not have been more than ten seconds, but the news channels had got their photo op, the newspapers a front-page picture. Nitish was left red-faced. He told his aides